

NOVEL BY JAKE BERKO



THE CURE

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PROLOGUE



September 29, 2035

The streets of Bellevue had never seemed so empty. Once a bustling, vibrant hub, the city now echoed with a heavy silence, disturbed only by the distant sirens and the occasional crackle of public announcements urging residents to stay inside.

Stores were shuttered, windows boarded, and graffiti tainted abandoned buildings, each a desperate plea for saving. A newspaper tumbled down the sidewalk, caught in a gust of wind, its headline proclaiming "doom" in bold, black ink.

At the corner of a major intersection, a makeshift memorial had taken over the pavement. Candles had burned down to pools of wax, surrounding faded photographs and handwritten notes dampened by the morning mist.

A poem left by an anonymous resident of Bellevue lay dormant on the ground.

*A quiet whisper heard by no one
The city streets dim with no light
A swarm of bugs the only life
What have we become*

The people here are going crazy they say

*I can see it
They start to laugh at the incorrect things
At funerals, at bees with no stings*

*Life as we knew it was no more
Buildings shuttered, thieves broke windows
The cops didn't know where to start
And then they joined in*

*Hospital beds lay dormant
With an aura of melancholy
As nurses fled the cities
And left the people for dead*

*It only took days
Not long once it happened
To unravel into something else
Unrecognizable, perhaps*

*It spread far, it spread fast
Insanity spread through droplets
Until the last sane man started laughing
And no one was left to mourn him*

Across the country, in a high-security research facility, hidden beneath layers of steel, Dr. Julian Mercer adjusted his lab coat, studying the latest test results projected on massive screens surrounding him. His expression was unreadable as it usually was, yet his posture showed a quiet confidence. "Dr. Mercer," an assistant approached nervously. "The president is on the line. They need to know how close we are."

Mercer glanced at the screen again, then back at the assistant. A faint smile curled his lips.

“Tell them we have it,” he said, his voice smooth and assured. “We’ve found the cure.”

Chapter 1



March 13, 2032

Riley Hartfield came to school with a headache and a lesson plan she already knew was going to be tough. Teaching sometimes had its rewards: the occasional essay that stood out, the rare moment a kid's face lit up when they genuinely understand something, but today wasn't going to be one of those days. She knew it before she even opened her classroom door. Today she was going over the *Great Gatsby*, and 25 students were going to look at her like she'd personally chosen to ruin their lives.

Principal Eichner caught Riley in the hallway on her way to class, saying her name like a statement, not a greeting. "Riley. Lunch. My office." He was already moving when he said it, and there was no time to even respond.

She spent the entire morning dreading the meeting.

The lesson went exactly as expected. She talked about Daisy and the green light while a boy in the back row drew on his notebook cover, and two girls in the middle passed notes between one another and chuckled. Riley pressed on. She'd done harder things.

The one who actually concerned her was Jason Fredericks.

He sat in the back corner, as usual, but today was different. Not his usual sighing, eye-rolling, and jokes that no one thought were funny. This was something else. His

face was flushed with a deep crimson red, and his eyes darted around the room restlessly. When Marcus accidentally knocked his pencil case off the desk and it clattered to the floor, Jason stood up.

A look of pure rage flashed across his face. Fists at his sides. Chest rising and falling too fast.

The room went quiet.

“Jason.” Riley kept her voice quiet and steady. “Sit down.”

He looked at her, and for a moment she wasn’t sure he actually saw her. Then it seemed like something clicked in his mind, and he sat down slowly, like a machine powering down. His face was still red when the bell rang and he shuffled out without a word.

Riley stared at his empty chair for a second longer than she needed to.

Principal Eichner’s office smelled like burnt coffee and carpet cleaner. He gestured to the chair across the desk, as though he was trained to deliver bad news on a daily basis.

“The students here love you, Riley,” he started, which told her immediately that whatever came next was going to be bad. “But it’s come to my attention that the grading on Jason Fredericks’ last three exams is being viewed as, well, targeted.” He said the word carefully, like he was defusing the situation. “His father has filed a formal complaint. He sits on the district board, as you know. He’s claiming you’re creating a hostile environment for his son.”

Riley looked at him.

She had never, in her career, thought about throwing something. She thought about it now. She thought about Jason’s mostly-blank quiz sitting at the bottom of her grading pile, the one with the single scrawled question

across the top: Why does this matter? She thought about the crude drawing in the margin. She thought about him standing over Marcus's pencil case this morning with his fists clenched, his face red as a burn.

"I grade Jason the same as every other student," she said, trying to contain her anger. "I give him the grade he deserves."

Eichner nodded slowly, the way one nods when they agree but can't explicitly say so. "I understand your position. This is a formality. I know you, Riley. I expect this to resolve quickly." He pauses. "But the code of conduct requires an internal audit. Grade-book access, third-party mediation. You'll be notified about the timeline."

He kept talking. Riley stopped listening.

She was thinking about Jason's quiz, about the question scrawled upon the upper edge. About how his father expects his position to be able to fix his child's inadequate effort like a magic wand.

Why does this matter?

She had no good answer. Not today.

She didn't go to the teachers' lounge during her break. She went back to her classroom instead, where the smell of whiteboard markers and floor wax felt like a familiar sanctuary.

She sat at her desk and started grading. The stack took her through two cups of cold coffee and most of the afternoon. Outside her window, the Bellevue sky went gray and then an even darker gray.

That night, she poured a glass of wine, put on a sitcom she'd already seen, and let her dog Leo curl up against her legs on the sofa. The apartment was quiet and warm.

She was almost done when she drifted to the news. She caught it mid-sentence, the anchor spoke in a calm and collected way, trying to sound reassuring:

—early-stage cases of HRSV-30 have presented with unusual agitation and irritability before the onset of other symptoms. Officials stress there is no cause for widespread concern. The strain remains under—”

Riley changed the channel.

She finished grading. She rinsed her glass. She turned off the lamp and fell asleep with Leo at her feet, the apartment dark and still.

She didn’t think about Jason Fredericks again. She wouldn’t, not until the morning his desk was empty, and then the morning after that, and every morning after that.

Chapter 2



Riley received a phone call from the school late one night. She's at home now, and doesn't know why they would possibly be calling her. They never do outside of business hours. It's an automated message saying that she needs to join a mandatory information session tomorrow morning before classes start, about health and safety. She's confused why there would need to be some message that is so urgent that it needs to be relayed the next morning.

The next morning, the faculty meeting felt less like an information session and more like a scolding. The teachers were gathered in the library, sitting on low chairs meant for students, clutching travel mugs for coffee. Principal Eichner stood at the front, his usual demeanor replaced by a worried, trembling one.

"As per the districts new guidance," Eichner said, reading directly from a sheet of paper. "We are implementing immediate zero-tolerance hygiene protocols. If a student appears flushed, lethargic, or exhibits *any* behavioral irregularities, they are to be sent to the nurse immediately. Do not engage. Do not attempt to de-escalate. Just isolate them."

Riley exchanged a glance with the history teacher next to her. *Behavioral irregularities?* Since when was the nurse responsible for teenage attitude problems?

“Is this about that flu on the news?” Someone asked from the back. “The HRSV-thing?”

Eichner didn’t look up from his paper. “This is about maintaining a safe learning environment. That is all. Go to your rooms.”

The dismissal was abrupt. The room filled with the scraping chairs and murmurs of confusion, but Riley didn’t linger. She had her own anxieties to manage.

The situation yesterday had been the tipping point. Fredericks had always been a bit of a class clown, but yesterday was different.

The bell rang. 24 students shuffled in, loud and chaotic as always. Riley stood by the whiteboard, her eyes instinctively scanning the back row near the window.

The desk was empty, as it has been for the past few days.

“Does anyone know where Jason is?” Riley asked, trying to sound casual as she marked the rest of the roll.

“Sick,” a girl in the front row said, popping her gum. “My brother takes the bus with him. Jason’s mom said he was burning up.”

Riley paused, her finger hovering over the tablet. She thought about Principal Eichner’s speech this morning.

She also thought about how Fredericks had been acting a little unusual, his face flushed with an irritation that didn’t match the situation.

She’d spent the whole day thinking Jason Fredericks was her biggest problem. She’d been wrong about that. She’d been wrong about almost everything.

Chapter 3



Riley didn't think much of it when an unknown man was brought into the classroom the next day. She knew it was coming, but she didn't know what their role was. Jason wasn't even in the classroom the past week –*his illness must've been pretty serious*, she thought.

The man introduced himself as Mr. Thorne. He was younger than most of the district's subs, wearing a crisp polo shirt and a lanyard that looked a bit too heavy to just hold an ID. He didn't ask Riley for a lesson plan or where the extra pens were kept. Instead, he took a stool in the far corner of the room, positioned perfectly to see every row of desks.

"Just pretend I'm not here, Ms. Hartfield," Thorne said with a polite, practiced smile.

Riley nodded, though "extra eyes" felt like an understatement. As she began her lecture, she tried to find her usual flow, but the atmosphere in the room was strange.

She noticed Thorne wasn't looking at the books or the whiteboard. Every time a student shifted loudly in their seat or muttered to a neighbor, Thorne's head would tilt ever so slightly. He held a thin, matte-black tablet in his lap. His thumb moved in small, rhythmic swipes, his eyes darting from the screen to the students and back again.

By the end of the week, the "Thorne Factor" had settled into a dull, slightly uncomfortable routine. Riley found that

if she didn't look directly into his corner, she could almost forget he was there. He never spoke, never offered to grade papers, and never stayed for the faculty lunch. He simply arrived with the bell and vanished when the final whistle blew.

Life outside of her room resumed its usual rhythm. On Thursday evening, Riley found herself at the local grocery store. She picked up a bunch of bananas, pre-made chicken, and a bottle of the Italian red she liked. At the checkout, the cashier, a kid who had been in her English class a few years back, looked exhausted.

"Rough shift, huh?" she asked, offering a sympathetic smile.

"Just everyone's in a mood, Ms. Hartfield," he muttered, rubbing his eyes. "People are just... edgy. Someone got into a shouting match over a parking spot outside. Over a *parking spot*."

"It's the season," Riley said, sliding her card through the reader. "Flu going around, everyone's a bit tired."

"Yeah. Must be."

She drove home to her small apartment, the heater in her car rattling as it fought off the Bellevue chill. When she let herself in, Leo greeted her with the usual thumping of his tail against the hardwood.

She spent the evening in a way that felt blissfully normal. She poured a small glass of the wine, put on an old sitcom, and sat on her sofa to grade her papers. Every so often, she would find a typo or a poorly constructed metaphor and sigh, her red pen hovering over the page.

It was a quiet, domestic peace.

The next day was a blur of distracted students and the heavy, silent weight of Mr. Thorne in the corner. As the final

bell rang and the teenagers poured out into the hallway, Riley stayed at her desk to pack her bag.

Thorne didn't leave immediately. He stood by the window, his matte-black tablet finally tucked into his satchel.

"Have a good weekend, Mr. Thorne," Riley said, testing the air. "I hope my math lecture wasn't too dry for your notes."

Thorne turned. For the first time all week, he looked at her with something resembling actual interest, though his eyes remained cool. "Your teaching is excellent, Ms. Hartfield. Very thorough."

"Good to know," she said, forced a smile. "I wasn't sure what the district was looking for in these evaluations."

Thorne paused, his hand on the doorframe. "Evaluations?" He said the word like it was foreign. "I think there's been a misunderstanding." He tilted his head, "Ms. Hartfield, I'm not here to watch you." He patted his satchel. "I'm here to watch *them*."

Before she could ask what that meant, he was gone, disappearing into the sea of students in the hall.

Chapter 4



Riley stood silent, motionless in her classroom. What could Thorne possibly mean by what he just said? This whole week, she was under the impression that she was being evaluated for the “grading discrepancies” in her classroom with Jason, but Jason wasn’t even in her classroom. Not once. Not since that Monday when he’d been flushed and angry.

Riley’s eyes drifted to Jason’s empty desk in the back corner.

She thought about Thorne’s tablet. The way his thumb had moved across the screen. She assumed he was taking notes on her lesson plans, her classroom management. But he’d never looked at the whiteboard. Never glanced at her grade book.

He’d only watched the students. A cold knot formed in her stomach.

She remembered Tuesday. Chloe had coughed through the entire period that made Riley wince. Thorne had looked up immediately, his eyes locking onto Chloe’s seat. He’d made a note. Riley thought it was about the disruption. But it wasn’t.

Wednesday. Marcus and Tyler had gotten into it over a borrowed pencil. Not playful bickering, but real anger. Marcus had stood up, fists clenched, face red, and for a moment Riley thought he was actually going to swing. Thorne’s head had tilted. Another note.

Thursday. Emma had snapped at her best friend over nothing, her voice sharp and vicious in a way that didn't match her usual demeanor. Thorne had watched. He'd swiped.

Riley caught her breath. She turned slowly, looking at rows of desks. Twenty-four seats. Twenty-four students who'd sat here every day this week. Who'd shared pencils and passed papers and breathed the same recycled air.

The same air Jason Fredericks had been breathing before he got sick. Her hands felt cold.

HRSV-30.

The news had called it mild. A new strain. Something doctors were monitoring. But if it was just a flu, why was Thorne here? Why was he tracking who sat where, who touched what, who coughed when?

Riley's eyes moved back to Jason's desk. Then to the desk directly in front of it- Marcus' seat. Marcus, who'd had to be separated from Tyler. Marcus, who'd looked flushed and furious over a pencil.

Then to Chloe's desk, two rows over. Close enough.

Her pulse quickened.

Thorne hadn't been watching for misbehavior. He'd been watching for *symptoms*. Mapping spread. Documenting contact.

Riley grabbed her bag with shaking hands and walked toward the door. The hallway stretched out before her, filled with students moving between classes. Their voices seemed too loud, too sharp. She passed a boy shoving his locker door so hard it rattled. A girl arguing with her friend, her face red with an anger that seemed too big for whatever they were fighting about.

She was halfway to the faculty lounge when she saw him.

Danny Kowalski, a seventh grader she recognized from the reading group she'd helped run last spring, was being walked down the hallway by Principal Eichner and a woman Riley had never seen before. The woman wore a lanyard identical to Thorne's. She had one hand loosely on Danny's shoulder, guiding him forward as someone trained to look unalarmed.

Danny did not look unalarmed. His face was flushed a deep red, and his eyes darted around the hallway with a frantic, unfocused energy. He was muttering something under his breath, his hands balling into fists at his sides.

"Keep moving Daniel", Eichner said. His voice was quiet and even.

Danny didn't even respond. He just kept muttering to himself.

Principal Eichner's eyes flicked up and caught Riley's for a brief second. There was something in his expression she'd never seen before. Not anger, not frustration.

Fear.

Then he looked away, steering Danny toward the side exit by the gymnasium. The door swung shut behind them with a metal click.

Riley stood still as the crowd of students flowed around her. She watched the closed door for a moment longer, then kept walking.

Near the nurse's office, she slowed. Through the narrow window, she could see two students sitting in the waiting chairs- both of them staring at nothing with the same glassy, restless look she'd seen on Danny's face. One of them was picking at the skin around his thumbnail, over and over, drawing blood without seeming to notice.

Riley kept walking.

Thorne had been mapping it. Contact tracing. Watching to see who would be next.

Jason had been first. And whatever he'd had- whatever HRSV-30 really was beneath the careful language of *mild symptoms* and *monitoring*- it hadn't stayed with him.

She thought about her students. Twenty-four of them, sitting in those desks every day, breathing the same air, passing the same papers, touching the same doorknobs.

Then she thought about herself.

Chapter 5



The following Monday, six desks were empty. Riley stood at the front of the room and counted them without meaning to. Six. She recognized each one by its owner. Marcus, who had stood over a fallen pencil case with his fists clenched. Chloe, who had coughed through two full periods without stopping. Tyler. Emma. A quiet boy named Pratt who sat by the door and had never once caused her a problem.

And Jason's desk, which had been empty so long it had started to feel normal.

She taught the lesson anyway. The remaining students were subdued in a way that didn't feel like teenage boredom. It felt like something else. They kept glancing at the empty seats. Nobody passed notes. Nobody drew on their notebook covers. They just sat there, very still, and watched her like she might know something they didn't.

By Wednesday, the faculty lounge felt like a waiting room. Teachers moved through it quietly, refilling coffee without speaking, checking their phones with the same tight expression. Someone had taped a note to the refrigerator from the district:

Effective immediately, any staff member presenting symptoms including, but not limited to: elevated agitation, behavioral dysregulation, fever above 101F, or disorientation

is required to report to administration before leaving the building.

Behavioral dysregulation. She thought that was a careful way to say what she'd seen on Jason's face. What she'd seen on Danny's face as Eichner walked him down the hall. What she'd seen on Marcus and Emma and Chloe before their desks were empty.

The news had stopped being background noise.

That week it was unavoidable. It followed her from her kitchen in the morning to her car to the break room television that nobody ever used to watch but now played constantly, volume low, just loud enough to make out words. *Containment. Pandemic. Transmission.* They still used the word mild occasionally, though it had started to sound like a habit rather than a fact.

She watched a reporter stand outside a hospital in Seattle, describing the behavioral component with clinical detachment. "Patients exhibit pronounced episodes of agitation and emotional dysregulation in the early stages, often preceding the onset of fever." Behind the reporter, through the glass entrance doors, Riley could see a man in a hospital gown standing very still in the middle of the lobby, staring at nothing.

She turned it off and graded papers until midnight. Thursday, she passed two police cars parked outside the convenience store on her street. The window had been broken. Glass on the sidewalk caught her eye. A small group stood outside watching, but not in the normal way. It was like they were expecting something else to happen, but nothing would.

Friday morning, the school was quieter than she'd ever heard it.

In the hallway, she counted six more absences just by looking. Twin brothers Trevor and Nigel, three girls from the reading group she ran after school, and math teacher named Henricks who had snapped at a student in the hallway.

It was starting to become a new normal.

She glanced quietly at her empty classroom, there was still 20 mins until her students, or at least the ones left, would enter.

She felt like writing.

*The sun beats down on my skin
The way it always has
Indifferent and warm
As if nothing has changed*

*A gust moves through my hair
And just for a moment I am somewhere else
Younger, softer
Standing in a yard I no longer own*

*There were stories then
Strangers offered them freely
Their whole lives poured out
As if time were something
We had too much of*

*I took them for granted
I took most things
Am I wasting my life?
Expecting someone to answer*

How could I have known

*That what was born into the world so easily
Could leave it just the same*

*But the sun still beats down
And we live to see another day.*

She wasn't sure if this would go anywhere. She thinks it probably won't. But writing was something that brought her peace in a world so filled with chaos.

Her students start entering into the room. 8 students are there by the time the bell rings. A record low. She's starting to get much more concerned.

Hours later, she leaves to go home. She's relieved that it is the weekend. She has plans to go to sleep by 8 PM.

As she's preparing dinner, she receives a phone call.

"The district has made the decision to suspend in-person instruction, effective immediately, until further guidance is issued. Teachers should collect essential materials on Monday. A formal communication will go out to families tonight."

She sat for a moment of silence in her kitchen. She looked at the pot of water on the stove, still waiting to boil. The hum of the refrigerator. Leo asleep on the kitchen floor, one paw tucked under his chin.

She set the phone face down on the counter.

She had known it was coming. She had known it the way you know a storm is coming before the clouds arrive, something in the pressure of the air, something in the way people had been moving through the hallways this week, quieter and faster, like animals that sense something humans can't. She had known it and still the phone call sat in her chest like something heavy.

Eight students today. Eight out of twenty four.

She thought about the other sixteen. Where they were right now. Whether they were sitting at dinner tables like she was, or lying in beds with the curtains drawn, or being walked down hallways by people with lanyards she didn't recognize.

She thought about her classroom. The rows of empty desks. The poem still folded in her jacket pocket. The whiteboard she would have to erase on Monday when she went back to collect her things.

Monday would be the last time she walked those halls.

She sat there with her hand on Leo's back until the room went fully dark, and the school would never reopen again.